After feeling peripheral, everything was much more fun when I was properly involved, on and off the field. If any of the DD players wanted to book a restaurant for dinner or to play golf, I was their go-to tour guide. And we played some outstanding cricket, winning 10 of our 14 group matches, finishing top of the round-robin league and advancing to a semifinal against Deccan Chargers at SuperSport Park in Pretoria, my home ground.

We batted first and scored 153 for eight in 20 overs. That total appeared defendable, but Adam Gilchrist soon proved otherwise. The brilliant Australian crashed 85 runs in only 35 balls, guiding his team to victory with two overs to spare. Deccan Chargers advanced to overcome RCB in the final and win the title.

The tournament returned to India in 2010, and I returned to the ranks of international players struggling to get a game. The Delhi Daredevils coaches selected Paul Collingwood, the England all-rounder, ahead of me, and I made only three appearances during the entire tournament. DD won seven and lost seven of their group matches, finishing fifth, eliminated with an inferior net run rate.

IPL contracts typically last three years and, although some eager DD officials had said they wanted to renew my contract, I really had no idea where I would be playing the following year.

Aside from taking salaries to a new level, the IPL had started to change the game in another important respect. The leading cricketers in the world, used to being rivals on the international stage, suddenly found themselves cast as teammates in IPL teams and many became friends.

In Delhi, I spent a great deal of time with players such as Zaheer Khan, Glenn McGrath, Virender Sehwag and others, going out for dinner, just sitting around, talking about cricket, chatting about life in general, getting to know them as people rather than as opponents, learning about their families and their passions.

Glenn is universally recognised as one of the great fast bowlers, but